

Hebrew Word Study and Armenian Word Study

Jesus' Teaching on Oaths, Swearing, Truth, and "Yes" and "No"

A Biblical-Linguistic Research Study of Matthew 5:33–37

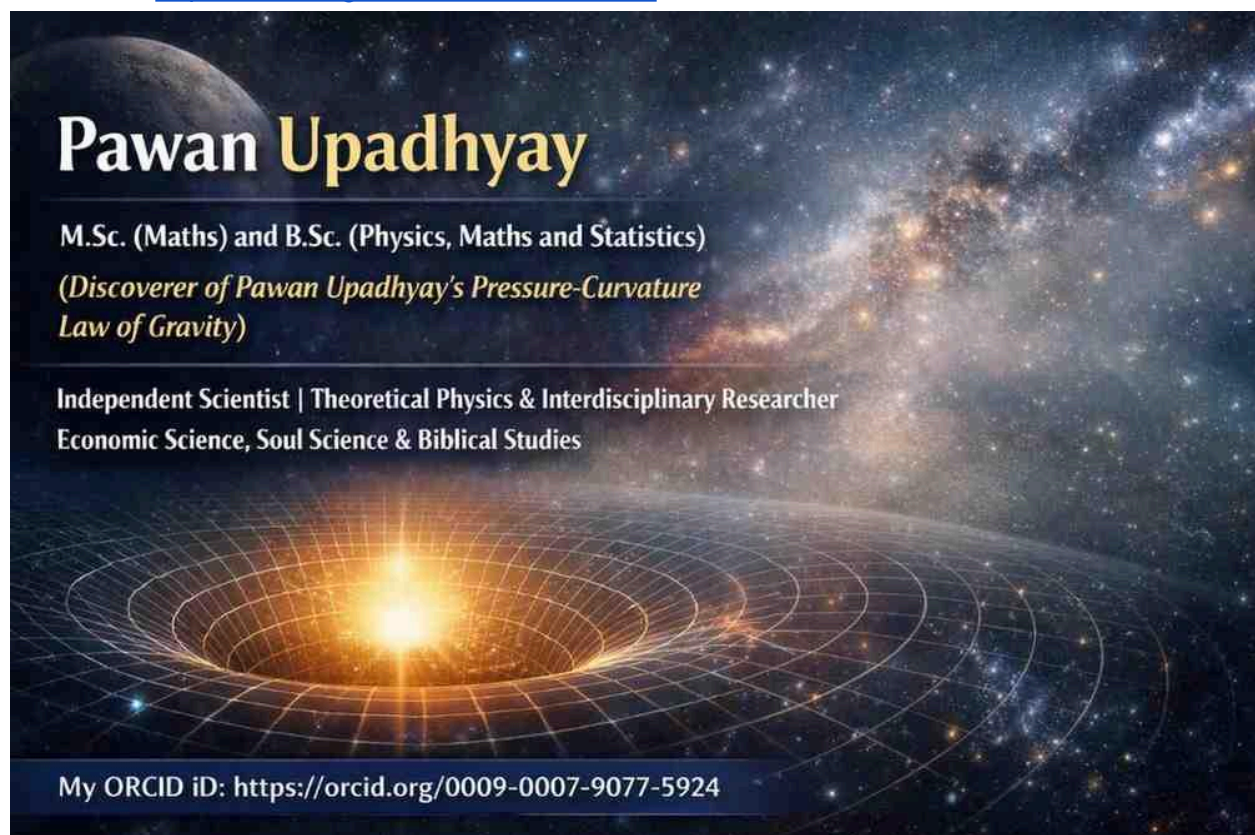
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Abstract

This research paper examines the biblical and linguistic vocabulary surrounding **oaths, swearing, promises, truth, and truthful speech**, with particular attention to Jesus' teaching in **Matthew 5:33–37**. The study compares the Hebrew vocabulary of the Old Testament with the Armenian terminology used in Christian translation and reception.

The central Hebrew term for “oath” is **שָׁבַע (shevu‘ah)**, derived from the root **שָׁבַע**, while the Hebrew verb **נִשְׁבַּע (nishba‘)** means “to swear” or “to take an oath.” Hebrew Scripture contains both human oaths and divine oaths, demonstrating that oath language has a significant place in biblical covenantal and legal contexts.

The Armenian New Testament uses the vocabulary **երդում (erdum)** for “oath” and forms of **երդվել (erdvel)** for “to swear.” In Armenian Matthew 5, Jesus' command is translated with the strong expression **«բնաւ մի՛ երդվեք»**, corresponding to the Greek **μη ὁμόσαι ὅλως**, “do not swear at all.”

The study argues that Matthew 5:33–37 should be read as a complete teaching. Jesus moves from the traditional command concerning oaths to a deeper ethical principle: the disciple's ordinary speech must already be truthful. His positive instruction is:

ναὶ ναί — yes, yes

οὐ οὐ — no, no

Thus, the Christian ethical alternative to manipulative or unnecessary oath-taking is **truthful, straightforward speech**.

This paper also proposes a theological framework distinguishing divine faithfulness, holy commitment, ordinary truthful speech, and sinful or false oath-taking, while carefully distinguishing this proposed framework from terminology explicitly used by Scripture.

1. Introduction

The subject of oaths occupies an important position in biblical ethics.

The Bible contains numerous examples of:

- people making oaths,
- people swearing before God,
- God Himself swearing,
- covenants being confirmed,
- promises being made,

- false oaths being condemned,
- and careless speech being judged.

Therefore, a study of Jesus' words in Matthew 5:33–37 must consider the larger biblical vocabulary.

Jesus says:

“Again, you have heard that it was said to those of ancient times, ‘You shall not swear falsely, but shall perform to the Lord what you have sworn.’ But I say to you, Do not swear at all...”

Jesus then concludes:

“Let what you say be simply ‘Yes’ or ‘No’; anything more than this comes from evil.”

The teaching is therefore not merely about one Greek verb. It concerns the relationship between:

oath → speech → truth → faithfulness → moral responsibility.

The purpose of this paper is to examine that relationship through Hebrew, Greek, and Armenian terminology.

2. The Full Saying of Jesus in Matthew 5:33–37

A word study should begin with the entire passage rather than one isolated phrase.

Matthew 5:33

Jesus begins:

“Again, you have heard that it was said to those of ancient times, ‘You shall not swear falsely, but shall perform to the Lord what you have sworn.’”

The background is the Old Testament requirement that a person must not make a false oath and must fulfill what has been sworn.

Matthew 5:34

Jesus continues:

“But I say to you, Do not swear at all...”

Greek:

ἐγὼ δὲ λέγω ὑμῖν μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

Transliteration:

egō de legō hymin mē omosai holōs

Literal sense:

“But I say to you, do not swear at all.”

The crucial expression is:

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

The verb **ὀμόσαι** means “to swear” or “to take an oath,” while **ὅλως** means “at all,” “altogether,” or “in any way.”

3. Matthew 5:35–36 — Jesus Continues the Argument

Jesus then mentions different objects by which people traditionally swore:

- heaven,
- the earth,
- Jerusalem,
- the head.

The significance is that human beings were attempting to strengthen their statements by appealing to something greater than themselves.

Jesus exposes the relationship between these things and God.

Heaven is associated with God's throne.

The earth is associated with God's footstool.

Jerusalem is associated with the great King.

Even the human head is not ultimately under absolute human control.

Jesus therefore challenges the assumption that human speech becomes absolutely reliable merely because a person attaches a sacred formula to it.

The problem is deeper than vocabulary.

It is a problem of **truthfulness**.

4. Matthew 5:37 — The Positive Command

Jesus concludes:

ἔστω δὲ ὁ λόγος ὑμῶν ναὶ ναί, οὐ οὐ

Transliteration:

estō de ho logos hymōn nai nai, ou ou

A literal rendering is:

“Let your word be ‘Yes, yes,’ ‘No, no.’”

This is extremely important.

Jesus does not merely say:

“Do not use certain oath formulas.”

He gives a positive alternative.

Your **word** should be truthful.

Your **yes** should mean yes.

Your **no** should mean no.

The Christian ethic therefore moves from **oath-dependent speech** toward **truth-dependent speech**.

5. Hebrew Word Study: שְׁבוּעָה (Shevu'ah)

The principal Hebrew noun for “oath” is:

שְׁבוּעָה

Transliteration: *shevu'ah*

Meaning: oath, sworn declaration; in some contexts, curse or oath-associated sanction.

The word derives from the Hebrew root:

שׁ-ב-ע

This root is associated with swearing/taking an oath.

Lexical resources identify שְׁבוּעָה as “oath,” and the Old Testament uses it in contexts involving human oaths as well as divine oath and promise.

6. Biblical Examples of שְׁבוּעָה

The Hebrew Bible uses שְׁבוּעָה in a variety of contexts.

For example:

Genesis 26:3

God speaks concerning the oath connected with Abraham.

The Hebrew text contains:

הַשְּׁבִיעָה

“the oath.”

The context demonstrates an important distinction:

God is not merely a human person making an uncertain promise. The divine oath is connected with God's covenant faithfulness.

Exodus 22:11

The expression:

שְׁבַעַת יְהוָה

can be understood as:

“an oath of the LORD.”

Numbers 30:2

The Hebrew text discusses a person who:

יִשָּׁבַע שְׁבַעָה

“swears an oath.”

Here the noun and verb occur together.

Joshua 9:20

The Israelites refer to:

הַשְּׁבוּעָה אֲשֶׁר־נִשְׁבַּעְנוּ

“the oath which we swore.”

These examples demonstrate that an oath in biblical Hebrew could establish a serious obligation and was not simply an ordinary casual statement.

7. Hebrew Verb: נִשְׁבַּע (*Nishba* ‘)

A second important Hebrew expression is:

נִשְׁבַּע

Transliteration: *nishba* ‘

Meaning:

“he swore,” “he took an oath,” or “he swore an oath.”

It belongs to the Hebrew root:

שבע

Thus we can distinguish:

Hebrew	Transliteration	Meaning
שְׁבוּעָה	<i>shevu'ah</i>	oath
נִשְׁבַּע	<i>nishba'</i>	he swore
שבע	<i>sh-b-</i>	root associated with swearing

This distinction is important for Hebrew word study.

שְׁבוּעָה is a noun.

נִשְׁבַּע is a verbal form.

8. Oath and Vow Are Not Identical

Another important Hebrew word is:

נָדָר (*neder*)

Meaning:

vow, vowed obligation.

The Hebrew Bible can distinguish between an oath and a vow, although the concepts can overlap.

This distinction prevents us from treating every promise, commitment, covenant, vow, and oath as linguistically identical.

A careful biblical study should therefore distinguish:

שְׁבוּעָה — **oath**

from

נָדָר — **vow**

and from

ברית — covenant.

9. Hebrew Word for Truth: אֱמֶת (*Emet*)

Jesus' teaching ultimately moves toward truth.

An important Hebrew word is:

אֱמֶת

Transliteration: *'emet*

Meaning:

truth, truthfulness, faithfulness, reliability.

This concept is essential for understanding the biblical ethics behind speech.

The problem with a false oath is not merely that the wrong formula was used.

The deeper problem is that the person's speech is not faithful to reality.

Thus:

oath → obligation → truthfulness

becomes an important biblical ethical relationship.

10. Hebrew Concept of False Swearing

The Old Testament explicitly condemns false oaths.

For example, Zechariah 8:17 includes the expression:

שְׁבַעַת שֶׁקֶר

shevu'at sheqer

meaning approximately:

“a false oath.”

This is especially important for the proposed theological distinction between truthful commitment and sinful oath-taking.

An oath does not automatically make a statement true.

A person can swear and still lie.

Therefore:

An oath is not the source of truth.

The moral truthfulness of the speaker remains decisive.

11. Armenian Word Study: Երդում (*Erdum*)

The Armenian Christian tradition uses:

Երդում

Transliteration: *erdum*

Meaning:

oath, swearing, solemn oath.

The related verb is:

Երդվել

Transliteration: *erdvel*

Meaning:

to swear / to take an oath.

Armenian therefore provides a useful translation-level parallel:

Concept

Armenian

oath	երդում
to swear	երդվել
truth	ճշմարտություն
yes	այո
no	ոչ

However, an important methodological point must be maintained:

Armenian is not the original language of Matthew's Gospel.

Matthew's New Testament text is preserved in Greek, and therefore Greek remains the primary linguistic evidence for the exact wording of Matthew 5:33–37.

Armenian is extremely valuable for studying how this teaching has been translated and received within the Armenian Christian tradition.

12. Armenian Matthew 5:34

The Armenian tradition renders Jesus' command approximately:

«Բայց ես ձեզ ասում եմ՝ բնավ մի՛ երդվեք...»

This corresponds closely in meaning to:

“But I say to you, do not swear at all.”

The important Armenian expression is:

բնավ մի՛ երդվեք

The central verb is:

երդվեք

“swear.”

The negative command communicates Jesus' prohibition in Armenian.

13. Armenian Matthew 5:37

The positive conclusion is especially important:

«Այո»-ն՝ «այո», և «ոչ»-ը՝ «ոչ»

That is:

“Yes” should be “yes,” and “no” should be “no.”

This corresponds to the Greek:

ναὶ ναί, οὐ οὐ

The principle is therefore preserved across the languages:

Greek:

ναί — yes

οὐ — no

Armenian:

այո — yes

ոչ — no

The linguistic form changes, but the ethical principle remains:

Truthful speech should not require an oath to make it trustworthy.

14. Full Linguistic Comparison

Concept	Hebrew	Greek	Armenian
oath	שבועה	ὄρκος	երդում
to swear	שבוע	ὀμνύω	երդվել
to swear — Matthew 5:34	—	ὀμόσαι	երդվեք
truth	אמת	ἀλήθεια	ճշմարտություն
word/speech	דבר	λόγος	խոսք

yes	—	ναί	այո
no	—	οὐ	ոչ
vow	נֶדֶר	εὐχή / related vocabulary	նվխտ/երդում depending on context
covenant	בְּרִית	διαθήκη	նվխտ

The table should not be interpreted as saying that these words are perfect one-to-one equivalents in every context. Biblical words have semantic ranges, and translation choices depend upon context.

15. The Greek Text Must Remain Central

Although this paper focuses on Hebrew and Armenian, Matthew 5:33–37 requires special attention to Greek.

The central phrase is:

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

mē omosai holōs

“Do not swear at all.”

The verb is:

ὀμόσαι

from:

ὀμνύω

Meaning:

to swear, take an oath.

The noun commonly associated with “oath” is:

ὄρκος

horkos

Meaning:

oath, sworn declaration.

Therefore:

ὄρκος = oath

ὀμνύω = to swear

ὀμόσαι = to swear / to take an oath

This distinction is important because Jesus' command in Matthew 5:34 uses the **verb ὀμόσαι**, not the noun ὄρκος.

16. Jesus' Teaching Is Larger Than One Word

Jesus' complete teaching can be represented as a progression:

Matthew 5:33

False oath is forbidden.

↓

Matthew 5:34–36

Do not attempt to strengthen human speech through sacred oath formulas.

↓

Matthew 5:37

Let your ordinary speech be:

Yes = yes

No = no

This progression suggests that Jesus is concerned with the **character of speech itself**.

The ultimate question is not:

“How powerful is my oath?”

The ultimate question is:

“Is my word true?”

17. Jesus and the Problem of Human Speech

Jesus' teaching elsewhere connects speech with the heart.

Human speech is not morally neutral.

A person's words can reveal:

- truth,
- falsehood,
- anger,
- deception,
- hypocrisy,
- faith,
- love,
- or corruption.

Therefore, simply adding an oath formula does not transform an untruthful heart into a truthful heart.

An oath cannot create moral integrity.

18. Divine Faithfulness and Human Oaths

The Bible contains an important theological distinction.

God can swear an oath.

Hebrews 6:13 says that when God made His promise to Abraham, He swore by Himself because there was no one greater by whom He could swear.

This is fundamentally different from human oath-taking.

God is:

- perfectly faithful,
- truthful,
- immutable,
- omniscient,
- and sovereign.

Human beings are:

- finite,
- limited in knowledge,
- changeable,
- morally imperfect,
- and capable of sin.

Therefore, a human oath cannot possess the same absolute character as God's faithfulness.

19. The Human Limitation

A person may sincerely make a promise today.

Tomorrow circumstances may change.

A person may also:

- forget,
- misunderstand,
- become afraid,
- become tempted,
- change intention,
- discover new information,
- or deliberately lie.

Therefore, human beings cannot guarantee the future with divine certainty.

This provides an important theological reason for taking Jesus' teaching seriously.

The Christian does not need to claim:

“My oath makes my word absolutely certain.”

Instead, the Christian should strive to make ordinary speech truthful.

20. The Relationship Between Oath and Truth

The following distinction is central:

Oath

An oath is a solemn form of assertion or commitment.

Truth

Truth concerns whether what is spoken corresponds to reality and whether the speaker is truthful.

Therefore:

Oath ≠ Truth

A person can make an oath and still lie.

A person can speak without an oath and tell the truth.

Jesus' teaching therefore moves the ethical center away from the **oath-formula** and toward the **truthfulness of the speaker**.

21. Proposed Fourfold Theological Framework

The following fourfold classification may be useful as a theological model, provided that it is clearly identified as a **proposed framework**, not as a formal biblical classification.

I. Divine Oath / Divine Faithfulness

This category refers to God's own self-confirming promise and faithfulness.

God's oath is fundamentally different from human oath-taking.

Within a Christological formulation, Christ may be described conceptually as the **embodiment and fulfillment of God's divine faithfulness**, because God's promises find their "Yes" in Christ.

This does not mean that Scripture formally gives Christ the title "Divine Oath."

Rather, it is a theological analogy.

II. Holy Oath / Holy Commitment

This category can describe a solemn commitment that is consistent with God's truth and righteousness.

However, even a sincere human commitment remains human.

It should not be confused with God's absolute faithfulness.

III. Simple Truthful Speech

This is the category most directly connected with Matthew 5:37.

Instead of depending upon oath formulas:

Yes should be yes.

No should be no.

This can be called:

Simple Truthful Speech

rather than "Simple Oath."

This terminology is preferable because Jesus' **yes/no speech is presented as an alternative to oath-taking**, not necessarily as another kind of oath.

IV. Evil, False, or Sinful Oath

The Bible explicitly recognizes false oaths.

A false oath can involve:

- deliberate deception,
- perjury,
- manipulation,
- injustice,
- misuse of God's name,
- harm against another person,
- or a commitment to wrongdoing.

Such an oath should not be regarded as holy simply because sacred language is used.

22. “An Oath Is Not Made Holy Merely by Invoking God”

This principle is important.

A person can say:

“I swear before God...”

and still speak falsely.

The invocation of God's name does not transform falsehood into truth.

Indeed, invoking God's name while deliberately lying makes the matter morally more serious.

Therefore:

Sacred language does not sanctify sinful speech.

Truthfulness must come first.

23. Evil Oaths and Destruction

An oath can become particularly dangerous when a person makes a solemn commitment to something evil.

For example, a person could bind himself to:

- revenge,
- murder,
- persecution,
- oppression,
- deception,
- corruption,
- or injustice.

The solemnity of the commitment does not make the action righteous.

A sinful commitment remains sinful.

Therefore:

The seriousness of an oath does not determine the goodness of its object.

The moral character of the commitment matters.

24. Jesus' Teaching and the Christian Life

Jesus' teaching can therefore be summarized through three principles:

1. Do not depend upon oath formulas.

μη ὀμόσαι ὅλως

“Do not swear at all.”

2. Speak truthfully.

ὁ λόγος ὑμῶν

“your word/speech”

3. Let yes and no remain simple and truthful.

vai vai, oũ oũ

“yes, yes; no, no.”

This creates a powerful ethical principle:

The Christian's ordinary word should be sufficiently truthful that an oath is unnecessary.

25. James 5:12 as a Parallel

James 5:12 gives a striking parallel to Matthew 5:34–37.

James says:

“Above all, my brothers and sisters, do not swear...”

and then:

“Let your yes be yes and your no be no.”

The Greek vocabulary closely parallels Matthew.

This strengthens the interpretation that straightforward truthful speech is central to Christian ethics.

The principle is not simply:

“Do not use one particular oath formula.”

It is:

Let your ordinary speech be trustworthy.

26. Matthew 5 and James 5 Together

The relationship can be represented:

Matthew 5:33–37

Oath → Do not swear → Yes/No

James 5:12

Do not swear → Yes/No

Both passages emphasize the same ethical direction:

from oath-dependent speech toward truthful speech.

27. Hebrew–Greek–Armenian Conceptual Chain

The three linguistic traditions can be brought together carefully:

Hebrew

שבועה

Oath

נשבע

He swore

אמת

Truth / faithfulness

↓

Greek

ὄρκος

Oath

ὀμνύω / ὀμόσαι

To swear

ἀλήθεια

Truth

λόγος

Word/speech

ՎԱԻ / ՕՆ

Yes / no

↓

Armenian

Երդում

Oath

Երդվել

To swear

ճշմարտություն

Truth

Խոսք

Word/speech

Այո / ոչ

Yes / no

The languages differ historically and grammatically, but the central ethical movement is recognizable:

Oath → truthfulness → trustworthy speech.

28. Important Methodological Limitation

The Hebrew and Armenian evidence must not be treated as if all three languages were equally original for Matthew.

The correct order is:

1. Hebrew

Provides the Old Testament linguistic and theological background.

2. Greek

Provides the primary textual evidence for Matthew's New Testament wording.

3. Armenian

Provides an important Christian translation and reception witness.

Therefore, Armenian can illuminate how the teaching has been expressed in Armenian Christianity, but it cannot replace the Greek text when determining the original wording of Matthew.

29. Is Every Human Oath Automatically False?

A careful theological argument should avoid saying:

“Every human oath is automatically a lie.”

That is stronger than the biblical evidence requires.

A person can sincerely swear and intend to keep a commitment.

The stronger argument is:

Human oath-taking cannot possess the absolute perfection and certainty of divine faithfulness because human beings are finite, changeable, and sinful.

Therefore, Jesus' teaching directs believers toward a higher standard:

truthful speech without dependence on oath-taking.

30. Is Every Oath Legally a Crime?

The theological claim must also be distinguished from a legal claim.

Scripture may condemn:

- false swearing,
- perjury,
- deception,
- misuse of God's name,

- and sinful commitments.

But modern legal systems may permit or require certain forms of oath or affirmation.

Therefore, the theological statement:

“Christians should not swear”

should not automatically be converted into the legal statement:

“Every oath is a crime.”

Those are different claims.

This paper is concerned primarily with **biblical theology and Christian ethics**, not with the criminal law of a particular country.

31. “Divine Oath” as a Theological Expression

The expression “**Divine Oath**” can be used within the proposed theological framework, but it requires precision.

Scripture explicitly speaks about:

- God's oath,
- God's promises,
- God's faithfulness,
- God's Word,
- God's covenant,
- and Christ as the fulfillment of God's promises.

However, “**Divine Oath**” is not a standard biblical title for the Trinity.

Therefore, a scholarly formulation would be:

“Within this theological framework, ‘Divine Oath’ is used as a conceptual expression for God's absolute faithfulness and self-confirming promise.”

This preserves the user's theological concept while avoiding the claim that the Bible literally names the Trinity “the Divine Oath.”

32. Christ and the Divine Faithfulness

A Christological formulation can be made more precisely.

Christ is:

- the eternal Word,
- the fulfillment of God's promises,
- the revelation of God's truth,
- and the embodiment of God's faithfulness.

Therefore, within this framework:

Christ may be described conceptually as the embodiment of the Divine Oath because God's promises reach their definitive “Yes” in Him.

This is a theological interpretation, not a claim that “Divine Oath” is a formal biblical name for Jesus.

33. The Trinity and One Divine Faithfulness

The Father, Son, and Holy Spirit are not three gods.

Therefore, if “Divine Oath” is used theologically, it should not suggest:

- three divine oaths,
- three competing divine promises,
- or three separate divine sources of truth.

Rather:

One God

One divine truth

One divine faithfulness

while maintaining the personal distinctions of Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

Thus “one Divine Oath” can function as an analogy for the **unity of divine faithfulness**, not as a replacement for Trinitarian doctrine.

34. The Ethical Contrast

The central contrast can therefore be expressed:

Human Oath-Centered Speech	Christian Truth-Centered Speech
“I swear...”	“Yes.”
“I swear before God...”	“My word is true.”
Sacred formula	Truthful character
External strengthening	Internal integrity
Oath-dependent credibility	Truth-dependent credibility
Formal guarantee	Faithful speech

Jesus' teaching directs the disciple toward the second column.

35. Central Thesis

The central thesis of this study is:

A human oath remains a human oath. It does not become divine merely because the speaker invokes God's name. Human beings remain finite, mutable, and affected by sin. Therefore human oath-taking cannot possess the absolute character of divine faithfulness. In Matthew 5:33–37, Jesus directs His disciples away from oath-dependent speech and toward straightforward truthful speech: “Yes” should be “yes,” and “no” should be “no.”

36. Final Conclusion

The Hebrew, Greek, and Armenian evidence together provides a rich linguistic framework for understanding Jesus' teaching.

The Hebrew Bible demonstrates that oaths were serious declarations involving truth, obligation, covenant, and accountability.

The principal Hebrew vocabulary includes:

שבועה — oath

נשבע — to swear / he swore

אמת — truth / faithfulness

The Greek New Testament then gives the precise wording of Jesus:

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

“Do not swear at all.”

Jesus' conclusion is:

ναὶ ναί, οὐ οὐ

“yes, yes; no, no.”

The Armenian Christian tradition communicates the same teaching through:

երդու՛մ — oath

երդվել — to swear

այո — yes

ոչ — no

The most important conclusion, however, is ethical rather than merely lexical.

Jesus does not teach His disciples to become better at making powerful oaths.

He teaches them to become truthful people.

The goal is not:

“Make your oath stronger.”

The goal is:

“Make your word truthful.”

Therefore:

Do not use an oath to make falsehood appear true.

Do not use God's name to strengthen deception.

Do not make sinful commitments.

Do not depend upon solemn formulas to establish credibility.

Let your “yes” be yes.

Let your “no” be no.

Let truthfulness characterize ordinary Christian speech.

In this sense, the deepest Christian alternative to the human oath is not another oath.

It is **truth**.

Yes should be yes.

No should be no.

And the believer's word should be faithful because the believer follows the God who is Himself perfectly faithful.

Key Biblical Vocabulary

Hebrew

- שְׁבוּעָה — *shevu'ah* — oath
- נִשְׁבַּע — *nishba'* — he swore / took an oath
- נֶדֶר — *neder* — vow
- בְּרִית — *berit* — covenant
- אֱמֶת — *'emet* — truth / faithfulness

Greek

- ὄρκος — *horkos* — oath
- ὀμνύω — *omnyō* — to swear
- ὀμόσαι — *omosai* — to swear / to take an oath
- ἐπιορκέω — *epiorkeō* — to swear falsely / perjure oneself
- λόγος — *logos* — word / speech
- ἀλήθεια — *alētheia* — truth
- ναί — *nai* — yes
- οὐ — *ou* — no

Armenian

- երդում — *erdum* — oath
- երդվել — *erdvel* — to swear
- ճշմարտութիւն — truth
- խոսք — word / speech
- այո — yes
- ոչ — no

Primary Biblical Passages for Further Study

1. **Matthew 5:33–37** — Jesus' teaching on oaths and truthful speech
2. **James 5:12** — “Do not swear”; yes should be yes and no should be no
3. **Exodus 20:7** — God's name and truthful use of His name
4. **Leviticus 19:12** — false swearing in God's name
5. **Numbers 30:2** — making and fulfilling an oath
6. **Deuteronomy 23:21–23** — fulfilling vows
7. **Zechariah 8:17** — false oath
8. **Hebrews 6:13–18** — God's oath and promise
9. **2 Corinthians 1:18–20** — God's promises and their “Yes” in Christ
10. **John 1:1–14** — Christ as the Word

Research Summary

The linguistic evidence supports a distinction between **oath-taking** and **truthful speech**. The Hebrew Bible provides the background of oath vocabulary and practice; the Greek text of Matthew provides the primary wording of Jesus' teaching; and Armenian demonstrates how the teaching has been transmitted in a major Christian translation tradition.

The central principle may therefore be stated:

The Christian should not need an oath to make truthful speech believable. The Christian's "yes" should be yes, and the Christian's "no" should be no.

Hebrew and Armenian Word Study of “Oath” and “To Swear”

A Biblical and Christian-Linguistic Study of נִשְׁבַּע, נִשְׁבָּעָה, նրդում, and նրդվել

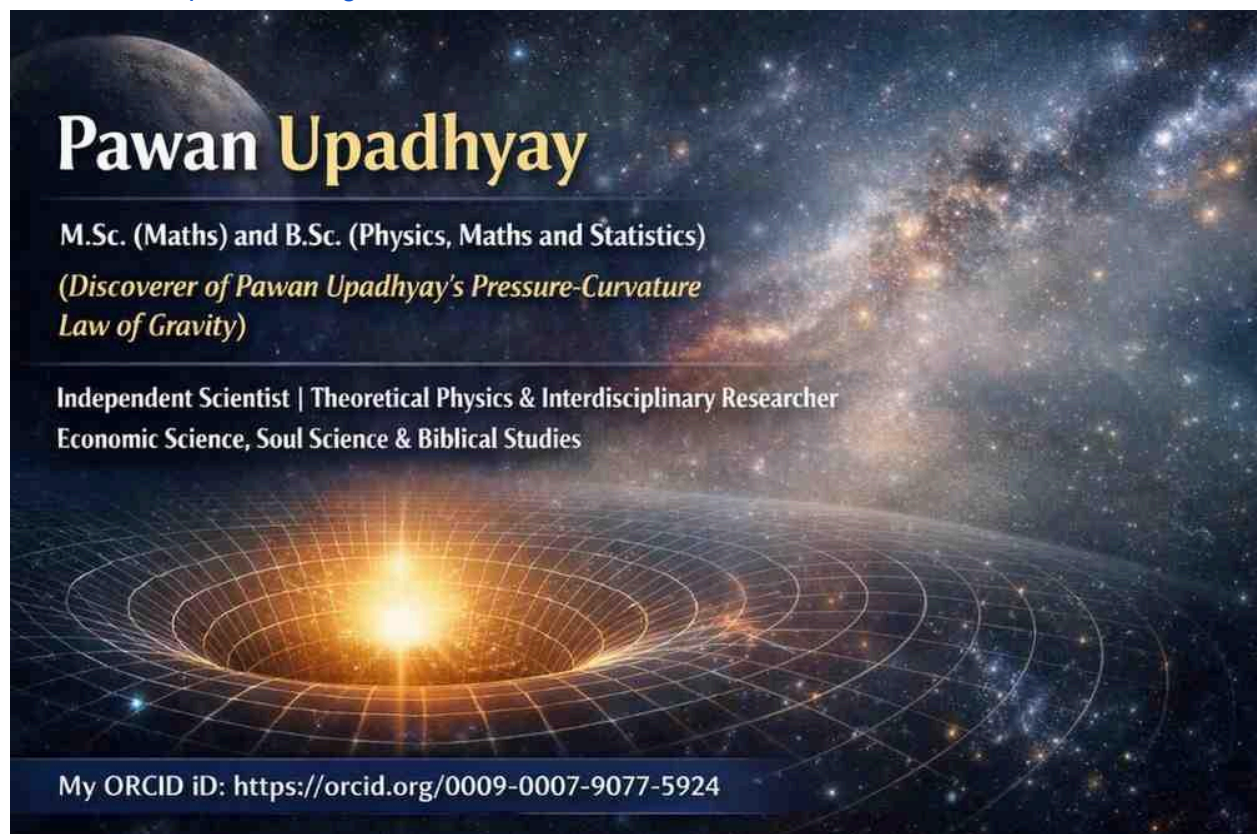
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The concepts of “**oath**” and “**to swear**” have a long history in biblical and Christian tradition. The Hebrew Scriptures contain a developed vocabulary for oaths, vows, sworn declarations, truthfulness, and false swearing. Armenian Christian Scripture later expresses these concepts through its own vocabulary.

A study of these languages is valuable because it shows how the biblical concept of oath-taking is understood across different linguistic traditions.

This article focuses specifically on **Hebrew and Armenian**.

The Hebrew language provides the Old Testament foundation, while Armenian provides an important Christian translation and reception tradition.

1. What Is an Oath?

An oath is a solemn declaration or commitment.

In biblical and religious contexts, an oath may involve:

- a declaration of truth,
- a solemn promise,
- a commitment,
- a witness,
- God's name,
- responsibility before God,
- or consequences for breaking the commitment.

The biblical concept therefore involves much more than simply saying:

“I promise.”

An oath places special solemnity upon the speaker's words.

2. Hebrew Word for “Oath”: שבועה

The principal Hebrew noun for “oath” is:

שבועה

Transliteration: *shevu'ah*

Meaning:

oath

The word belongs to the Hebrew root:

ש-ב-ע

This root is central to the biblical vocabulary of swearing.

Therefore:

שְׁבוּעָה = oath

This is the key Hebrew noun to remember when studying the biblical concept.

3. Hebrew “To Swear”: **נִשְׁבַּע**

The principal biblical Hebrew verb associated with oath-taking is:

שָׁבַע

and its common biblical form:

נִשְׁבַּע

Transliteration: *nishba'*

Meaning:

“to swear”

or, depending on the grammatical form and context:

“he swore.”

Thus:

נִשְׁבַּע = to swear / he swore

while:

שבועה = oath

The distinction is similar to the difference between an **action** and the **noun describing the oath**.

4. The Hebrew Root ש-ב-ע

The root:

ש-ב-ע

is important in understanding Hebrew oath vocabulary.

The root is associated with words relating to:

- swearing,
- oath,
- and the number seven.

The Hebrew word for seven is:

שבע (*sheva'*)

while:

שבועה (*shevu'ah*)

means:

oath.

There has been historical discussion concerning the relationship between the concepts of “seven” and “oath,” but one should not simply claim that the word “oath” literally means “seven.”

For biblical word study, the safest conclusion is:

שבועה specifically means “oath,” and נשבע belongs to the Hebrew vocabulary of swearing.

5. Hebrew Oath and God's Name

The Hebrew Bible gives special importance to oaths involving God's name.

Leviticus 19:12 warns:

“You shall not swear falsely by my name.”

This is a crucial biblical principle.

The problem is not merely the existence of an oath.

The problem occurs when a person connects an oath with God's holy name and then speaks falsely.

The relationship can therefore be expressed:

Oath + God's name + falsehood = serious violation.

This provides an important foundation for Christian teaching about the misuse of sacred language.

6. False Oath in Hebrew Thought

The Hebrew Bible strongly condemns false swearing.

An oath was expected to correspond to truth.

A person could not legitimately use an oath as a tool for deception.

Therefore, biblical oath-taking involves a moral responsibility:

The sworn word must be truthful.

This gives us an important relationship:

שבועה — oath

and:

אמת — truth / faithfulness.

7. אֱמֶת — Truth

The Hebrew word:

אֱמֶת (*emet*)

means:

- truth,
- faithfulness,
- reliability,
- firmness.

This is especially important for an oath study.

A truthful oath must be consistent with אֱמֶת.

The biblical ideal is therefore not merely:

“Make an oath.”

It is:

“Speak truthfully.”

An oath that deliberately contradicts truth becomes false swearing.

8. Oath and Vow

Hebrew also has vocabulary concerning vows.

One important word is:

נֶדֶר (*neder*)

meaning:

vow.

A vow is a solemn commitment, often made to God.

This should not simply be equated with שְׁבוּעָה, “oath.”

The concepts are related, but they are not identical.

Therefore:

Oath ≠ automatically vow.

This distinction is important when developing a precise biblical theology.

9. Hebrew Oath and Covenant

Another related concept is:

בְּרִית (berit)

meaning:

covenant.

A covenant can involve promises, obligations, signs, witnesses, and relationships.

An oath may occur in a covenant context, but:

oath ≠ covenant.

These terms should therefore be kept distinct.

10. Hebrew Oath and Human Responsibility

Biblical oath-taking places responsibility upon the person who swears.

A person who makes an oath is not simply producing words.

He is making a solemn declaration that carries moral responsibility.

Therefore:

The more solemn the declaration, the greater the responsibility for truthfulness.

This becomes especially important when God's name is involved.

11. Armenian Christian Vocabulary

Armenian Christianity developed its own vocabulary for oath-taking.

The principal Armenian noun is:

Երդում

Transliteration: *erdum*

Meaning:

oath / swearing / solemn oath.

The related verb is:

Երդվել

Transliteration: *erdvel*

Meaning:

to swear / to take an oath.

Thus:

Երդում = oath

Երդվել = to swear

This is the principal Armenian vocabulary relevant to the subject.

12. Armenian “Oath”

The Armenian word:

Երդում

refers to an oath or solemn sworn declaration.

It can be used when a person makes a solemn assertion or commitment.

Therefore, the basic relationship is:

Երդում → **oath**

and:

Երդվել → **to swear**.

This provides a clear Armenian linguistic distinction between the noun and verb.

13. Armenian “To Swear”

The Armenian verb:

Երդվել

means:

to swear / to take an oath.

Thus the basic vocabulary is:

Noun

Երդում

oath

Verb

Երդվել

to swear

This vocabulary is used in Armenian Christian biblical translations when translating biblical passages concerning oath-taking.

14. Armenian Matthew 5:34

An Armenian rendering of Matthew 5:34 uses the vocabulary of **երդվել** in Jesus' prohibition.

The Armenian text includes:

«Բայց ես ձեզ ասում եմ՝ բնավ մի՛ երդվեք...»

The essential meaning is:

“But I say to you, do not swear at all.”

The word:

երդվեք

comes from the Armenian verb **երդվել**.

Thus Armenian directly communicates Jesus' command using its normal vocabulary for swearing.

15. Armenian “At All”

The Armenian expression:

բնավ

can communicate:

at all / by no means / altogether not

in this context.

Therefore the Armenian sentence preserves the force of Jesus' prohibition:

բնավ մի՛ երդվեք

“do not swear at all.”

This is significant because the Armenian translation does not turn the statement into a general prohibition against speaking.

It specifically uses the vocabulary of oath-taking.

16. Armenian Yes and No

Matthew 5:37 provides the positive alternative.

Armenian uses:

այո

for:

yes

and:

ոչ

for:

no.

Thus the Armenian Christian text preserves the same conceptual contrast:

oath-taking

versus:

yes and no.

This makes the ethical teaching accessible in Armenian:

Do not swear.

Let yes be yes.

Let no be no.

17. Armenian and Truth

The Armenian word for truth is:

ճշմարտութիւն

Meaning:

truth / truthfulness.

This provides a useful theological connection:

Երդում — oath

and:

ճշմարտութիւն — truth.

The Christian ethical goal is not merely solemn speech.

It is truthful speech.

18. Hebrew and Armenian Side by Side

We can now compare the principal vocabulary:

Concept	Hebrew	Armenian
Oath	שבועה	Երդում
To swear	נשבע	Երդվել
Truth	אמת	ճշմարտութիւն
Vow	נדָר	context-dependent
Covenant	בְּרִית	context-dependent
Yes	כן / context-dependent	ոյո
No	לא	ոչ

The table demonstrates that both Hebrew and Armenian have distinct terminology for oath-taking.

19. Hebrew and Armenian: An Important Difference

There is a major historical difference between these two languages.

Hebrew

Hebrew is the principal language of the Old Testament.

Therefore Hebrew oath vocabulary provides the **biblical background** for understanding the subject.

Armenian

Armenian is a later Christian language of biblical translation and interpretation.

Therefore Armenian vocabulary provides a **Christian reception and translation witness**.

This distinction is important.

Armenian should not be treated as though Matthew originally wrote his Gospel in Armenian.

For Matthew 5:34, the Greek text remains the primary textual evidence.

Armenian helps us understand how the Christian tradition expressed the teaching in Armenian.

20. Hebrew Oath → Armenian Oath

The conceptual comparison can be represented:

Hebrew

שבועה

oath

↓

Armenian

Երդում

oath

Likewise:

Hebrew

נִשְׁבַּע

to swear

↓

Armenian

Երդվել

to swear

These are not etymologically related words.

They are equivalent concepts expressed in different languages.

21. Etymology Must Not Be Confused with Meaning

This is an important principle of word study.

Hebrew:

שְׁבוּעָה

and Armenian:

Երդում

do not share the same historical root.

Yet both can mean:

oath.

Similarly:

נִשְׁבַּע

and:

երդվել

belong to completely different languages and etymological histories while communicating the concept:

to swear.

Therefore, theological meaning should not be constructed merely from similarities between words in different languages.

Meaning is established through:

- grammar,
 - context,
 - usage,
 - history,
 - and literary setting.
-

22. Hebrew Oath and Christian Reception

The Hebrew Bible establishes the importance of truthful oath-taking.

It also shows that invoking God's name creates serious responsibility.

The Armenian Christian tradition receives the teaching of Jesus and expresses it through Armenian oath vocabulary:

երդվել — to swear

and:

երդում — oath.

Thus the Christian tradition carries the ethical concern forward:

Sacred language must never become an instrument of falsehood.

23. Oath and Falsehood

The most serious problem occurs when an oath is combined with falsehood.

A person may use solemn language to make a false statement appear credible.

This produces a contradiction:

Solemn form + false content = corrupt oath.

The Hebrew Scriptures condemn false swearing.

The Christian tradition continues the concern.

Jesus' teaching goes further by emphasizing simple truthful speech.

24. Oath and God's Holiness

An oath involving God must be treated with particular seriousness because God's name is holy.

The issue is therefore not merely:

“Did someone make a promise?”

The issue can become:

“Did someone invoke the name or authority of God while making this declaration?”

If so, falsehood becomes especially serious.

This is why biblical teaching about oaths must be connected with holiness and truth.

25. Human Oath Cannot Become Divine

This linguistic study also supports an important theological distinction.

A human being may say:

“I swear before God.”

But the human being remains a creature.

The oath remains human speech.

The use of God's name does not transform the human oath into God's own divine speech.

Therefore:

Human oath remains human oath.

It cannot become divine merely through religious language.

26. Divine Oath

The Bible nevertheless speaks of God swearing an oath.

Hebrews 6:13–18 is especially important.

God confirms His promise with an oath.

But God's oath is categorically different from a human oath.

God is:

- perfectly faithful,
- perfectly truthful,
- sovereign,
- and without the limitations of human knowledge.

Human beings are:

- finite,
- fallible,
- changeable,
- and affected by sin.

Therefore:

Divine oath and human oath should not be equated.

27. Human Finiteness and Oaths

A human being cannot know everything.

A person cannot guarantee every future circumstance.

A sincere human commitment can be affected by:

- unexpected circumstances,
- weakness,
- ignorance,
- changing conditions,
- or failure.

This does not mean every human oath is intentionally false.

The stronger theological conclusion is:

Human oath-taking cannot possess the absolute perfection of divine faithfulness.

28. The Fourfold Theological Framework

The Hebrew and Armenian study can contribute to the proposed fourfold theological framework:

1. Divine Oath

God's perfect sworn faithfulness.

2. Holy Oath

A human sacred commitment directed toward truth and holiness.

3. Simple Truthful Speech

Ordinary speech characterized by truthful:

Yes

and:

No.

4. Evil Oath

An oath corrupted by:

- falsehood,
- deception,
- injustice,
- corruption,
- oppression,
- or evil purpose.

This is a theological model, not a four-category classification explicitly named in the Hebrew or Armenian Bible.

29. Why Simple Truthful Speech Is Important

The third category is best called:

Simple Truthful Speech

rather than:

Simple Oath.

Why?

Because the Christian alternative presented by Jesus is not another type of oath.

The principle is:

Yes should mean yes.

No should mean no.

The goal is trustworthy speech.

30. Hebrew and Armenian Contribution to the Study

The Hebrew language contributes:

שבועה — oath

נשבע — to swear

אמת — truth

The Armenian Christian tradition contributes:

տրդում — oath

տրդել — to swear

ճշմարտություն — truth

Together they provide a useful comparative linguistic framework.

But they must be interpreted according to their historical roles:

Hebrew = Old Testament linguistic background

Armenian = Christian translation/reception tradition

31. A Linguistic Summary

The central vocabulary can be summarized:

Hebrew

שבועה
shevu'ah
oath

נשבע
nishba'
to swear / he swore

אֱמֶת
'emet
truth / faithfulness

Armenian

Երդում
erdum
oath

Երդվել
erdvel
to swear / take an oath

ճշմարտություն
chshmartutyun
truth

32. Final Comparison

The comparison can be expressed simply:

Hebrew: שבועה = oath
Armenian: Երդում = oath

and:

Hebrew: נִשְׁבַּע = to swear
Armenian: Երդվել = to swear

The languages are different, but the basic concept is recognizable.

The biblical and Christian traditions both understand an oath as a solemn form of speech that carries moral responsibility.

Conclusion

The Hebrew and Armenian study of “**oath**” and “**to swear**” provides an important linguistic foundation for understanding Christian teaching about sworn speech.

The Hebrew Bible uses:

שְׁבוּעָה (*shevu'ah*)

for:

“oath.”

It uses:

נִשְׁבַּע (*nishba'*)

for:

“to swear.”

Hebrew also gives us:

אֱמֶת (*'emet*)

for:

truth and faithfulness.

The Armenian Christian tradition uses:

Երդում (*erdum*)

for:

“oath.”

and:

Երդվել (*erdvel*)

for:

“to swear.”

The Armenian vocabulary is particularly significant because Armenian Christian Scripture uses **Երդվել** in translating Jesus' command concerning oath-taking.

Thus, across these linguistic traditions, oath-taking is understood as a solemn form of human speech carrying serious responsibility.

The theological distinction remains essential:

Human oath is human speech.

Divine faithfulness is divine.

A human being cannot transform his own words into God's words simply by invoking God's name.

Therefore, the deepest Christian concern remains **truthfulness**.

An oath should never become an instrument of:

- falsehood,
- deception,
- corruption,
- injustice,
- or harm.

The proposed theological framework can therefore be summarized:

Divine Oath

God's perfect faithfulness.

Holy Oath

Sacred human commitment.

Simple Truthful Speech

Truthful human “yes” and “no.”

Evil Oath

Oath-taking corrupted by falsehood or evil purpose.

The Hebrew Scriptures provide the ancient biblical foundation, while Armenian Christianity provides a later linguistic expression of the Christian teaching.

At the heart of the entire study is one fundamental principle:

Truth must remain truth.

And in the Christian understanding of Jesus' teaching:

Yes should be yes.

No should be no.

Seven and Shevu'ah

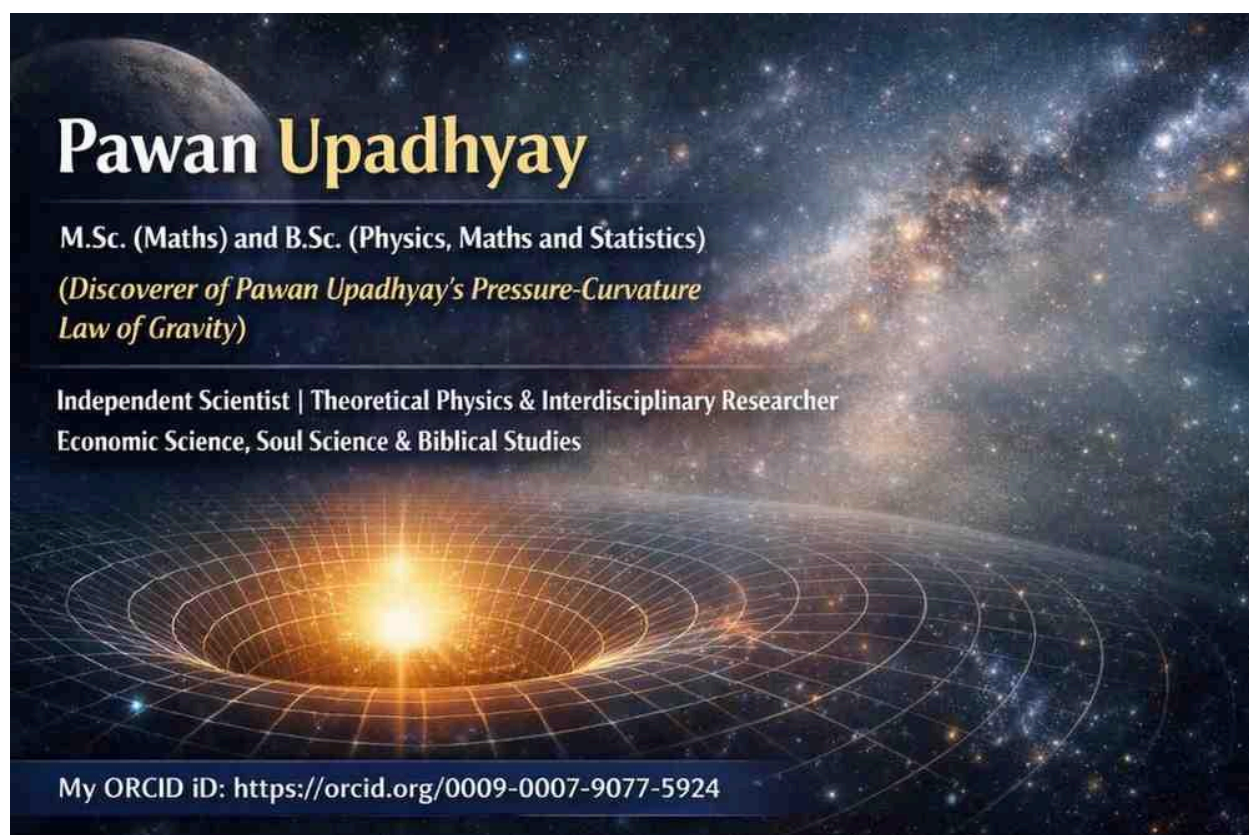
A Hebrew Word Study of שְׁבוּעָה, שָׁבַע, שָׁבַע, and נִשְׁבַּע

The Biblical Relationship Between “Seven,” “Swearing,” and “Oath”

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Abstract

This research paper investigates the relationship between the Hebrew words שבע (*sheva*‘, seven), שבוע (*shava*‘, to swear), שבועה (*shevu*‘ah, oath), and נשבע (*nishba*‘, he swore).

The relationship is particularly significant in **Genesis 21:22–31**, where Abraham and Abimelech establish a covenant concerning a well. Abraham sets apart **seven ewe-lambs**, and the narrative concludes by explaining the name באר שבע (*Be’er Sheva*‘) in connection with the fact that the two men swore there. The Hebrew text intentionally places the concepts of **seven** and **swearing** together.

The Hebrew noun שבועה (*shevu*‘ah) means “oath,” while שבוע (*shava*‘) is the verb “to swear.” The number שבע (*sheva*‘) means “seven.” Traditional Hebrew lexicography has long recognized a relationship between the words, sometimes explaining *shava*‘ as conceptually connected with “seven oneself” or binding oneself by seven.

However, the paper distinguishes between **lexical relationship**, **biblical wordplay**, and **historical etymology**. It argues that Genesis 21 provides strong biblical evidence for a deliberate association between seven and oath, while cautioning against reducing the meaning of every oath to the numerical meaning “seven.”

The study also examines the theological significance of seven in Scripture, the connection between oath and witness, the meaning of Beersheba, God's oath, and the relationship of these concepts to Jesus' teaching in Matthew 5:33–37.

1. Introduction

The Hebrew Bible contains a fascinating linguistic relationship between:

Seven

שֶׁבַע — *sheva*´

To swear

שָׁבַע — *shava*´

Oath

שְׁבוּעָה — *shevu´ah*

He swore

נִשְׁבַּע — *nishba*´

At first glance, “seven” and “oath” appear to be completely different concepts.

One is a number.

The other is a solemn declaration.

Yet Hebrew places them within the same consonantal framework:

שִׁבְעַ

Shin — Bet — Ayin

This makes the relationship worthy of careful biblical investigation.

The most important biblical passage is Genesis 21.

2. The Hebrew Number Seven

The Hebrew word for seven is:

שֶׁבַע

Transliteration: *sheva*⁶

Meaning: seven.

It appears throughout the Hebrew Bible.

The number seven is prominent in:

- creation,
- Sabbath,
- ritual cycles,
- purification,
- festivals,
- covenantal symbolism,
- repeated acts,
- and various biblical narratives.

Genesis 1 establishes the seven-day structure of creation, with the seventh day distinguished as Sabbath.

Thus seven becomes a major biblical numerical pattern.

However, the presence of seven in Scripture does not mean that every occurrence of seven carries a special symbolic meaning.

Context must determine its significance.

3. שָׁבַע — “To Swear”

The Hebrew verb:

שָׁבַע

Transliteration: *shava*⁶

means:

“to swear”

“to take an oath”

The verbal form occurs extensively in the Hebrew Bible.

The lexicographical tradition has explicitly noted the connection between the verb meaning “to swear” and the Hebrew word for “seven.” Brown–Driver–Briggs, for example, records the traditional explanation that *shava* ‘ may be understood in relation to “seven oneself” or being bound by seven.

This is one reason the relationship between seven and oath has attracted so much attention in Hebrew studies.

4. נִשְׁבַּע — “He Swore”

A very important biblical form is:

נִשְׁבַּע

Transliteration: *nishba* ‘

Meaning:

“he swore”

This form belongs to the same Hebrew verbal system.

For example, Genesis 21:31 says:

כִּי־שָׁם נִשְׁבַּעוּ שְׁנֵיהֶם

ki-sham nishbe ‘u shenehem

approximately:

“because there they both swore.”

The exact form here is plural:

נִשְׁבַּעוּ — *nishbe ‘u*

“they swore.”

This word becomes especially important because it appears immediately after the seven-lamb episode.

5. שְׁבוּעָה — “Oath”

The noun is:

שְׁבוּעָה

Transliteration: *shevu‘ah*

Meaning:

“oath”

“sworn declaration”

This is the noun corresponding to the concept of oath-taking.

Thus:

Hebrew	Transliteration	Meaning
שֶׁבַע	<i>sheva‘</i>	seven
שָׁבַע	<i>shava‘</i>	to swear
נִשְׁבַּע	<i>nishba‘</i>	he swore
נִשְׁבְּעוּ	<i>nishbe‘u</i>	they swore
שְׁבוּעָה	<i>shevu‘ah</i>	oath

The shared consonants are:

שִׁבְעַ

This creates a significant Hebrew word-family relationship.

6. Genesis 21: The Key Biblical Passage

Genesis 21:22–31 provides the most important narrative for this study.

Abimelech approaches Abraham concerning their relationship.

A covenant is established.

Genesis 21:27 says:

Abraham took sheep and cattle and gave them to Abimelech, and the two made a covenant.

The Hebrew says:

וַיִּקַּח אֲבִרְהָם צֹאן וּבָקָר

and then:

וַיַּכְרֹתוּ שְׁנֵיהֶם בְּרִית

“and the two of them made a covenant.”

Then something unusual happens.

7. Abraham Sets Apart Seven Lambs

Genesis 21:28 says:

וַיִּצַּב אֲבִרְהָם אֶת־שִׁבְעַ כְּבָשֹׁת הַצֹּאן

Approximately:

“Abraham set seven ewe-lambs of the flock apart.”

The crucial word is:

שִׁבְעַ

seven

The narrative deliberately emphasizes the number.

Abimelech asks:

“What mean these seven ewe-lambs?”

Genesis 21:29.

Abraham explains that they will serve as a witness that he dug the well.

8. Seven as a Witness

Genesis 21:30 says:

“These seven ewe-lambs you shall take from my hand, that they may be a witness to me that I dug this well.”

The Hebrew word:

לְעֵדָה

means:

“**as a witness.**”

This is extremely important for understanding the narrative.

The seven lambs are not presented simply as an ordinary gift.

They function as a **witness**.

Therefore, the narrative contains:

Seven

-

Witness

-

Covenant

-

Swearing

This combination provides the foundation for the name **Beersheba**.

9. Genesis 21:31 — Beersheba

Genesis 21:31 says:

עַל־כֵּן קָרָא לַמָּקוֹם הַהוּא בְּאֵר שֶׁבַע

followed by:

כִּי שָׁם נִשְׁבָּעוּ שְׁנֵיהֶם

Approximately:

“Therefore that place was called Beersheba, because there they both swore.”

The Hebrew name is:

בְּאֵר שֶׁבַע

Be'er Sheva

Usually translated:

“Well of Seven”

or

“Well of the Oath.”

The Hebrew narrative intentionally allows both ideas to interact.

A biblical commentary on the Hebrew text specifically notes the double significance: the name can be understood in relation to **the oath** and **the seven**, with the seven lambs and the act of swearing deliberately brought together.

10. The Wordplay of Beersheba

This is the central linguistic phenomenon.

שֶׁבַע

sheva ^ʿ

“seven”

and

שָׁבַע

shava ^ʿ

“to swear”

are closely related in form and sound.

Genesis 21 brings them together through:

seven lambs

and

they swore.

Thus:

שֶׁבַע → **seven**

שָׁבַע → **swear**

שֶׁבַע בְּאֵר → **Beersheba**

The biblical narrator is therefore doing more than merely giving a geographical name.

The name preserves the memory of the covenant and the sworn relationship.

11. Is “Seven” the Literal Meaning of “Oath”?

This requires careful scholarly treatment.

It would be too simplistic to say:

“The Hebrew word for oath literally means seven.”

That statement does not adequately represent the complexity of Hebrew lexical history.

A more accurate formulation is:

The Hebrew words for “seven” and “swear/oath” are closely connected in form and are deliberately associated in biblical wordplay, especially in Genesis 21. Traditional lexicography has proposed that the oath terminology developed from the idea of seven or binding oneself by seven, but the exact historical etymology should be treated cautiously.

This distinction is important for a research paper.

12. Three Levels of Relationship

We should distinguish three different questions.

Level 1 — Lexical Relationship

The words:

שבע

and

שבע

share the consonants:

ש-ב-ע

This is an established feature of Hebrew vocabulary.

Level 2 — Biblical Wordplay

Genesis 21 intentionally places:

seven lambs

alongside:

they swore.

This is strong textual evidence of a wordplay connection.

Level 3 — Historical Etymology

Whether the verb “to swear” historically developed directly from the number “seven” is a more complicated linguistic question.

Traditional lexicons have proposed such a connection, but modern linguistic analysis should not automatically treat the traditional explanation as proven.

Therefore:

Wordplay = strong biblical evidence.

Historical derivation = requires caution.

13. Seven and Completeness

Seven has a major structural role in the Hebrew Bible.

The creation narrative provides the foundational example.

Genesis 1–2 establishes the seven-day pattern:

1. First day
2. Second day
3. Third day
4. Fourth day

5. Fifth day
6. Sixth day
7. Seventh day

The seventh day is distinguished by God's rest.

Consequently, seven becomes associated in biblical theology with completed cycles and sacred time.

However, “seven = perfection” should not be mechanically imposed on every biblical occurrence.

The meaning depends on context.

14. Seven and Oath: A Possible Conceptual Connection

If the traditional connection between *sheva*´ and *shevu´ah* is considered, an interesting theological concept emerges:

Seven

can represent a complete or established pattern.

Oath

establishes a solemn commitment.

Therefore, the oath may be understood conceptually as a **binding or established declaration**.

This is one reason traditional interpreters have connected the oath with the number seven.

But again, this is an interpretive explanation rather than a command that every oath must contain the number seven.

15. The Seven Lambs as Witness

Genesis 21 is particularly important because Abraham does not merely say:

“I promise that I dug this well.”

He gives a visible sign.

The seven lambs function as:

עֵדָה

“witness.”

This produces an important theological pattern:

Spoken commitment

-

Visible witness

-

Covenant

=

Established relationship

The oath is therefore connected with accountability.

16. Beersheba: Well of Seven and Well of the Oath

The Hebrew name:

בְּאֵר שֶׁבַע

can be understood in the double sense:

“Well of Seven”

and

“Well of the Oath.”

The biblical narrative itself provides the basis for this double meaning.

Seven lambs explain the numerical side.

Swearing explains the oath side.

Thus Beersheba becomes a linguistic memorial of the covenant between Abraham and Abimelech.

17. Genesis 26: Another Beersheba Connection

The relationship appears again in Genesis 26.

Isaac encounters Abimelech.

They discuss their relationship.

They swear to one another.

The narrative then associates the event with Beersheba.

This demonstrates that the association between the place and oath was not limited to the original Abraham narrative.

The location continues to carry covenantal significance.

18. Genesis 22: God's Oath

Another extremely important passage is Genesis 22:16.

After Abraham's obedience, God declares:

בִּי נִשְׁבַּעְתִּי

bi nishba'ti

approximately:

“By myself I have sworn.”

This is a profound biblical example.

Here the one swearing is not a sinful human being.

It is God.

God swears by Himself.

This connects directly with Hebrews 6:13, which explains that God swore by Himself because He had no one greater by whom He could swear.

19. Divine Oath and Human Oath

This distinction is essential.

Human oath

A finite person makes a solemn declaration.

Divine oath

God Himself makes a self-confirming declaration.

The two should not be treated as identical.

Human beings can:

- misunderstand,
- forget,
- change,
- sin,
- deceive,
- or fail.

God's faithfulness is fundamentally different.

Therefore, even if the same Hebrew verbal root is used, the **theological subject** is different.

20. The Root ש-ב-ע and Divine Faithfulness

The root gives us an important vocabulary:

שֶׁבַע

seven

שָׁבַע

swear

שְׁבוּעָה

oath

נִשְׁבַּע

he swore

This vocabulary allows Scripture to describe solemn commitment.

But the moral value of an oath depends on the truthfulness and righteousness of the one making it.

A false oath remains false.

A sinful oath remains sinful.

A divine oath is fundamentally different because God is perfectly faithful.

21. False Oath

The Hebrew Bible also speaks about false swearing.

For example, Leviticus 5:22–24 addresses situations involving false or dishonest oaths.

Jeremiah 5:2 speaks of people who swear falsely.

Zechariah 8:17 speaks of:

שְׁבַעַת שֶׁקֶר

shevu'at sheqer

“false oath.”

This is important.

The existence of an oath does not guarantee truth.

Therefore:

Oath ≠ Truth.

The oath can itself become an instrument of falsehood.

22. Oath and Curse

The Hebrew concept of oath can also contain an element of self-imprecation or consequence.

The one who swears places himself under serious obligation.

This explains why oath-taking is morally dangerous when the speaker is dishonest.

An oath is not merely:

“I strongly say this.”

It can carry the force:

“I bind myself to this declaration or commitment.”

Therefore false swearing is a serious moral violation.

23. The Sevenfold Idea and Binding

Traditional Hebrew interpretation sometimes explains the relationship between seven and oath as:

“seven oneself”

or

“bind oneself by seven.”

This interpretation is recorded in traditional lexicographical discussions of the root שבע.

The conceptual meaning is:

Seven → binding/completeness

Oath → binding declaration

This provides an attractive explanation for the linguistic relationship.

But it remains important to distinguish:

traditional etymological explanation

from

demonstrated historical linguistic derivation.

24. Theological Significance of Seven

The number seven appears in major biblical patterns:

- seven days of creation,
- seventh-day Sabbath,
- sevenfold patterns,
- seven-branched lampstand,
- seven-year cycles,
- Jubilee after seven cycles of seven years,
- repeated sevenfold structures in prophetic and apocalyptic literature.

These patterns show that seven has substantial symbolic and structural importance in biblical literature.

Nevertheless, not every seven automatically means “oath.”

The oath connection must be established by context.

Genesis 21 is one of the clearest contexts because the number seven and swearing occur together.

25. The Seven Lambs: A Covenant Sign

The seven lambs in Genesis 21 are especially significant.

They are:

- seven,
- separated,
- given by Abraham,
- received by Abimelech,
- described as a witness,
- and connected with the covenant concerning the well.

This gives us:

Seven

→

Witness

→

Covenant

→

Swearing

→

Memorial

The event is permanently remembered through the name:

Beersheba.

26. “Seven” Is Not Magic

A biblical study must avoid turning the number seven into a magical formula.

The Bible does not teach:

“Every oath must involve seven objects.”

Nor does it teach:

“Seven automatically makes an oath true.”

Genesis 21 is a specific covenantal narrative.

The seven lambs serve as a witness within that historical event.

The theological lesson is about **solemnity, witness, covenant, and accountability**, not magical power.

27. Connection to Jesus' Teaching

This Hebrew background becomes particularly interesting when we return to Jesus.

Jesus says in Matthew 5:33:

“You shall not swear falsely...”

He then says:

“Do not swear at all.”

And finally:

“Let your word be simply ‘Yes’ or ‘No.’”

The Old Testament background shows how serious oath-taking was.

Jesus then directs His disciples toward an even deeper ethical principle:

Truthfulness of ordinary speech.

The believer should not need a solemn oath to make the word trustworthy.

28. From Shevu'ah to Yes and No

We can express the theological development as:

Hebrew Bible

שבועה Oath

↓

Oath requires truthfulness

↓

False oath is condemned

↓

Jesus teaches

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

“Do not swear at all.”

↓

Jesus' positive principle

ναί — yes

οὐ — no

↓

Truthful ordinary speech.

This does not erase the Old Testament vocabulary.

Rather, Jesus' teaching places the ethical emphasis on the character of the speaker.

29. The Christian Principle

The relationship can therefore be summarized:

The purpose of truthful speech is not to create a stronger oath. The purpose is to eliminate the need for an oath as a guarantee of truthfulness.

A trustworthy Christian should be truthful before an oath is introduced.

Therefore:

“Yes” should already mean yes.

“No” should already mean no.

30. Seven and the User's Fourfold Framework

Within the proposed theological framework, the study of *sheva* and *shevu'ah* adds another dimension.

1. Divine Oath

God's own self-confirming promise.

2. Holy Commitment

A righteous commitment consistent with God's truth.

3. Simple Truthful Speech

“Yes” and “No.”

4. Evil or False Oath

A solemn declaration used for deception, sin, manipulation, or injustice.

The Hebrew study demonstrates that an oath carries seriousness and binding force.

But seriousness does not equal righteousness.

A false oath can be solemn and still be evil.

31. The Problem of Human Sin

The Bible presents human beings as morally imperfect.

Therefore, human oath-taking has an inherent vulnerability.

A person may sincerely swear today and later:

- change,
- fail,
- deceive,
- forget,
- or discover that the original statement was wrong.

This does not mean every oath is intentionally false.

It means that human beings do not possess divine immutability.

Consequently, Jesus' emphasis on truthful ordinary speech is especially significant.

32. Divine Oath and “Seven”

There is a beautiful theological distinction here.

The linguistic relationship between:

שֶׁבַע — seven

and

שְׁבוּעָה — oath

does not mean that God is “seven.”

Nor does it mean that the Trinity consists of seven.

The relationship belongs to Hebrew vocabulary and biblical wordplay.

Theologically, the important point is instead:

God's oath is absolutely trustworthy because God's character is absolutely faithful.

33. Christ and the Fulfillment of God's Promise

The New Testament develops the theme of divine faithfulness in Christ.

2 Corinthians 1:20 declares that God's promises find their "Yes" in Christ.

This creates an important theological connection with Matthew 5:37:

Human speech

Yes should be yes.

God's promises

Their definitive **Yes** is found in Christ.

Therefore, the Christian's truthful "yes" ultimately reflects the faithfulness of God revealed in Christ.

34. A Theological Word Chain

The study can therefore be summarized through the following conceptual chain:

שֶׁבַע

Seven

↓

שָׁבַע

To swear

↓

שְׁבוּעָה

Oath

↓

נִשְׁבַּע

To swear / he swore

↓

Witness

↓

Covenant

↓

Accountability

↓

Truthfulness

This is especially visible in Genesis 21.

35. Important Scholarly Caution

The strongest academic formulation is not:

“The word oath literally means seven.”

A better formulation is:

“The Hebrew vocabulary for seven and oath is connected through the consonantal root ש-ב-ע, and Genesis 21 deliberately exploits the relationship between שֶׁבַע (‘seven’) and the verbal forms of שָׁבַע (‘to swear’) in the naming of Beersheba.”

This statement is linguistically and exegetically safer.

Traditional lexicography has proposed a direct conceptual derivation from “seven,” but modern scholarship should distinguish that proposal from the undeniable literary wordplay in Genesis 21.

36. Conclusion

The Hebrew relationship between **seven** and **oath** is one of the most fascinating examples of biblical wordplay.

The principal words are:

שֶׁבַע

sheva' — seven

שָׁבַע

shava' — to swear

שְׁבוּעָה

shevu'ah — oath

נִשְׁבַּע

nishba' — he swore

The key biblical passage is Genesis 21:28–31.

Abraham sets apart:

seven ewe-lambs.

They become:

a witness.

Abraham and Abimelech then:

swear.

The place receives the name:

בְּאֵר שֶׁבַע

Be'er Sheva' — Beersheba.

The biblical narrative therefore brings together:

seven + witness + covenant + oath + memorial.

This does not prove that every use of “oath” historically originated simply from the number seven. The exact etymological history remains a matter requiring caution.

But the biblical wordplay is unmistakable and the traditional Hebrew association is significant.

Most importantly, the study leads back to the ethical teaching of Jesus.

An oath is solemn.

An oath can create obligation.

An oath can establish witness.

An oath can confirm a covenant.

But an oath cannot manufacture truth.

A false person can swear falsely.

Therefore, Jesus moves the believer beyond oath-dependent credibility:

“Let your word be simply ‘Yes’ or ‘No.’”

The ultimate Christian principle is therefore not:

“Make your oath stronger.”

It is:

“Make your word truthful.”

And this leads to the deepest distinction:

Seven is a number.

Shevu'ah is an oath.

Truth is a moral reality.

God's faithfulness is absolute.

Human faithfulness is limited.

Therefore the disciple of Christ is called to let ordinary speech become truthful enough that an oath is unnecessary.

Yes should be yes.

No should be no.

Truth should remain truth.

Selected Biblical Texts for Further Study

Genesis 21:22–31

The covenant between Abraham and Abimelech, seven ewe-lambs, witness, oath, and Beersheba.

Genesis 22:16–18

God's oath: **בִּי נִשְׁבַּעְתִּי** — “By myself I have sworn.”

Genesis 26:28–33

Isaac, Abimelech, covenant, and swearing at Beersheba.

Exodus 22:11

The oath associated with the LORD.

Leviticus 5:22–24

False and dishonest oath-taking.

Numbers 30:2

The obligation associated with a person's oath.

Deuteronomy 23:21–23

Vows and fulfillment.

Jeremiah 5:2

False swearing.

Zechariah 8:17

False oath.

Matthew 5:33–37

Jesus' teaching: do not swear; yes should be yes and no should be no.

James 5:12

Do not swear; let yes be yes and no be no.

Hebrews 6:13–18

God's oath and promise.

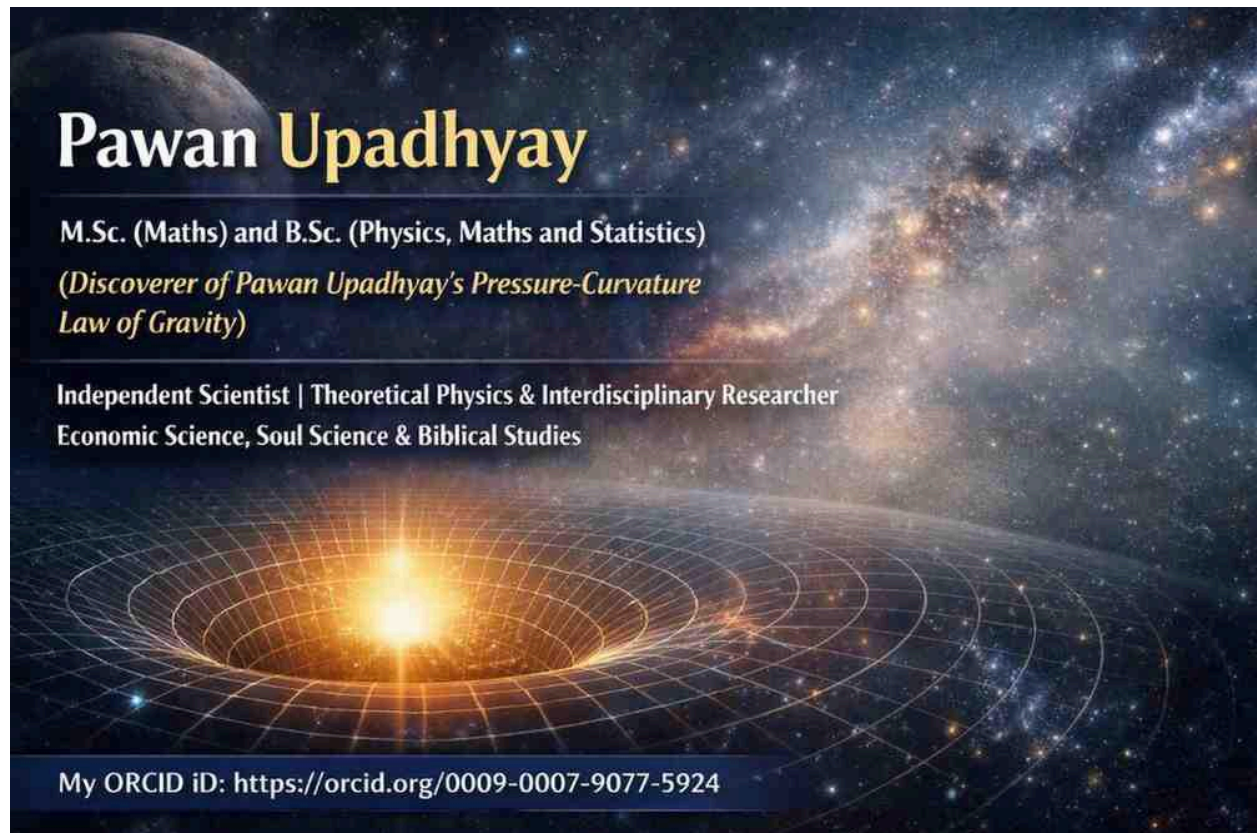
2 Corinthians 1:18–20

God's promises and their “Yes” in Christ.

Final Research Statement

The Hebrew terms שבע (*sheva* ‘, seven), שבוע (*shava* ‘, to swear), and שבועה (*shevu* ‘ah, oath) form a significant lexical and literary constellation in the Hebrew Bible. Genesis 21:28–31 provides the clearest biblical setting in which “seven” and “swearing” are deliberately brought together through the seven ewe-lambs, their function as a witness, the covenant between Abraham and Abimelech, and the naming of Beersheba. This relationship illuminates the seriousness of oath-taking while also showing why Jesus' teaching in Matthew 5:33–37 redirects the disciple from oath-dependent speech toward truthful speech: ‘Yes’ should be yes, and ‘No’ should be no.”

Hebrew and Greek Word Study of “Oath” and “To Swear”



https://archive.org/details/@pawan_upadhyay

Understanding נִשְׁבַּע, שְׁבוּעָה, ὄρκος, and ὁμνύω

The words “oath” and “to swear” have a significant place in the biblical languages. The Hebrew Bible and the Greek New Testament use specific vocabulary to describe oath-taking, sworn declarations, vows, truthfulness, and false swearing.

A careful study of these words is especially important for understanding Jesus' teaching in Matthew 5:33–37:

ἐγὼ δὲ λέγω ὑμῖν μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

“But I say to you, do not swear at all.”

The central Greek word is:

ὀμόσαι (*omosai*)

meaning:

“to swear” or “to take an oath.”

But Jesus' teaching must also be understood against the background of the Hebrew Scriptures, where the vocabulary of oath-taking is associated particularly with the Hebrew root ש-ב-ע.

This article therefore examines the Hebrew and Greek words side by side.

1. What Is an Oath?

An oath is a solemn declaration or commitment in which a person gives special force to his statement or promise.

In biblical contexts, an oath can involve:

- truthfulness,
- commitment,
- witness,
- responsibility,
- God's name,
- covenant relationships,
- promises,
- blessings,
- or consequences.

The Bible also warns against:

- false swearing,
- misuse of God's name,
- breaking vows,

- deception,
- and false testimony.

Therefore, the biblical concept of oath must be studied not merely as a vocabulary issue but as an ethical and theological issue.

2. Hebrew: The Word for “Oath”

The principal Hebrew noun is:

שְׁבוּעָה

Transliteration: *shevu‘ah*

Meaning:

“oath.”

It belongs to the Hebrew root:

ש-ב-ע (Š-B-‘)

The noun refers specifically to an oath or sworn declaration.

Thus:

שְׁבוּעָה = oath

This is the primary Hebrew noun that should be considered when studying the biblical concept of an oath.

3. Hebrew: “To Swear”

The principal Hebrew verb associated with swearing is:

שָׁבַע

Transliteration: *shava‘*

The relevant biblical form is frequently:

נִשְׁבַּע

Transliteration: *nishba*´

Meaning:

“he swore” / “he took an oath.”

Thus we have an important Hebrew distinction:

שְׁבוּעָה

oath

נִשְׁבַּע

swore / took an oath

The relationship is comparable to the Greek:

ὄρκος

oath

ὀμνύω

to swear

4. Hebrew Root ש-ב-ע

The root:

ש-ב-ע

is particularly important in biblical Hebrew.

The Hebrew oath vocabulary is associated with this root.

It is therefore useful to remember:

ש-ב-ע → oath / swearing

The root is also associated with the Hebrew word for “seven,” שֶׁבַע (*sheva* ‘).

The precise historical relationship between “seven” and oath terminology is a matter for specialized Hebrew lexicography and should not be reduced to the claim that “oath literally means seven.”

For biblical interpretation, the important point is that:

שבועה specifically means “oath.”

5. Hebrew Oath and God's Name

The Hebrew Bible gives particular importance to oaths involving God's name.

Leviticus 19:12 warns against:

swearing falsely by God's name.

This establishes a serious ethical relationship between:

oath + God's name + falsehood.

The problem is not simply that a person speaks solemnly.

The problem is that a person invokes God's holy name while making a false declaration.

This makes false swearing a serious religious offense.

6. Hebrew Oath and Truthfulness

The biblical concept of oath is closely related to truthfulness.

The Hebrew word:

אֱמֶת (*emet*)

means:

truth, faithfulness, reliability.

This creates an important theological relationship:

Oath → truth → faithfulness.

An oath is intended to establish or affirm truth.

When the speaker deliberately lies under oath, the oath is corrupted.

Therefore:

A truthful oath and a false oath are morally different.

7. Greek: The Word for “Oath”

The principal Greek noun is:

ὄρκος (*horkos*)

Meaning:

“oath.”

This is the basic Greek noun for a solemn oath or sworn declaration.

Thus:

ὄρκος = oath

The Greek New Testament uses this word in passages dealing with oath-taking.

8. Greek: “To Swear”

The principal Greek verb is:

ὀμνύω (omnyō)

Meaning:

“to swear” or “to take an oath.”

This is one of the most important words for understanding Jesus' teaching in Matthew 5.

From this verb comes the form:

ὀμόσαι (omosaī)

which appears in Matthew 5:34.

Therefore:

ὀμνύω → ὀμόσαι

The basic meaning remains:

“to swear / to take an oath.”

9. The Exact Form ὀμόσαι

Matthew 5:34 contains:

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

The word:

ὀμόσαι

is an **orist active infinitive** from ὀμνύω.

Therefore:

ὀμόσαι = to swear / to take an oath.

It is important not to translate this word as simply:

“to speak.”

Greek has other words for speaking, such as:

λέγω (*legō*) — to say / speak.

The use of **ὀμνύω** specifically identifies oath-taking.

10. Jesus' Complete Expression

Jesus says:

ἐγὼ δὲ λέγω ὑμῖν μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

Word by word:

Greek	Meaning
ἐγὼ	I
δὲ	but
λέγω	say
ὑμῖν	to you
μὴ	not
ὀμόσαι	to swear / take an oath
ὅλως	at all / altogether

The central phrase is:

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

“Do not swear at all.”

11. The Importance of ὅλως

The final word:

ὅλως (*holōs*)

means:

at all / altogether / completely.

Therefore:

μὴ ὁμόσαι ὅλως

has the strong sense:

“Do not swear at all.”

This wording is one reason Matthew 5:34 is central to Christian discussions about oath-taking.

There is scholarly debate concerning the precise scope of Jesus' prohibition. Some interpreters understand it comprehensively, while others understand Jesus as confronting particular oath practices, especially manipulative or evasive forms of oath-taking.

The Greek wording itself, however, clearly concerns **swearing**.

12. Greek Oath and Hebrew Oath

We can now compare the central words:

Concept	Hebrew	Greek
Oath	שבועה	ὄρκος
To swear	נשבע	ὁμνύω
To swear — form in Matthew	—	ὁμόσαι
Truth	אמת	ἀλήθεια

Word/speech

Hebrew terms vary by
context

λόγος

The languages are different, but both have a clear vocabulary for the concept of oath-taking.

13. Hebrew Background and Greek New Testament

The Hebrew Scriptures provide the theological background against which the New Testament teaching must be read.

The Old Testament contains:

- divine oaths,
- human oaths,
- vows,
- covenant commitments,
- prohibitions against false swearing,
- warnings against misuse of God's name.

Jesus' teaching in Matthew 5 therefore appears within this larger biblical tradition.

But Jesus' statement is striking because He says:

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

“Do not swear at all.”

He then directs His disciples toward simple speech.

14. Jesus' Alternative: Yes and No

Matthew 5:37 says:

ἔστω δὲ ὁ λόγος ὑμῶν ναὶ ναί, οὐ οὐ

The key words are:

λόγος — word / speech

ναί — yes

οὐ — no

Jesus therefore gives the believer a positive standard:

Let your word be yes, yes; no, no.

The Christian does not need an oath to make ordinary truthful speech credible.

15. Oath versus Word

This gives us a significant Greek contrast:

ὀμνύω

to swear

λόγος

word / speech

The Christian ethical movement is:

Oath-taking → truthful word.

The believer's speech should be trustworthy without requiring an oath.

This is why “**Simple Truthful Speech**” is a better theological expression than “Simple Oath.”

16. James 5:12

James reinforces Jesus' teaching:

μὴ ὀμνύετε

“Do not swear.”

James uses the same basic Greek verb:

ὀμνύω

He then says:

ναί ναί, οὐ οὐ

“Yes, yes; no, no.”

The lexical relationship between Matthew 5 and James 5 is therefore significant.

Both passages connect:

do not swear

with:

yes and no.

17. False Swearing in Greek

The Greek language also contains vocabulary for false swearing.

One important term is:

ἐπιορκέω (*epiorkeō*)

meaning:

to swear falsely / to commit perjury.

This distinction is important.

ὀμνύω

to swear

ἐπιορκέω

to swear falsely

Therefore, the Greek language distinguishes the act of oath-taking from its corrupt or false use.

18. Hebrew and Greek Concepts of False Oath

The Hebrew Bible also condemns false swearing.

The relationship can therefore be represented:

Hebrew

נִשְׁבַּע

to swear

•

שֶׁקֶר / falsehood

→

false swearing

Greek

ὀμνύω

to swear

•

ἐπιορκέω

to swear falsely

→

false oath-taking

The terminology of both biblical languages therefore recognizes the serious moral danger of false sworn speech.

19. Oath and Divine Authority

An oath can involve an appeal to a higher authority.

In biblical contexts, God's name can be invoked.

This creates a profound theological responsibility.

When someone invokes God's name, he is not merely strengthening his own statement.

He is associating his speech with the authority and holiness of God.

Therefore, false use of God's name is particularly serious.

20. Human Oath Cannot Become Divine

This provides an important principle for Christian theology:

A human oath remains a human oath.

A person may say:

“I swear before God.”

But the person remains human.

The statement remains human speech.

The invocation of God's name does not transform the speaker's words into God's own words.

Therefore:

Human oath cannot become divine merely through the invocation of God.

21. Divine Oath

Scripture does, however, speak about God swearing an oath.

Hebrews 6:13–18 describes God confirming His promise with an oath.

This raises an important distinction:

Divine oath

God's own sworn faithfulness.

Human oath

Human sworn speech.

These should not be treated as identical.

God is perfectly faithful.

Human beings are not.

God possesses perfect knowledge.

Human beings do not.

God is not limited by the weaknesses that characterize human beings.

22. Human Finiteness

Human beings are:

- finite,
- fallible,
- limited in knowledge,

- limited in power,
- subject to changing circumstances,
- capable of sin.

Therefore, even a sincere human oath cannot possess God's absolute character.

This does not mean that every human oath is intentionally false.

A person may sincerely make a commitment and later fail because of circumstances or human weakness.

The stronger theological statement is:

Human oath-taking cannot possess the absolute perfection of divine faithfulness.

23. Human Sin and Oath-Taking

Scripture presents humanity as sinful.

Romans 3:23 teaches that all have sinned.

Jesus also connects speech with the heart.

Therefore, the problem of oath-taking can become a problem of the heart.

A sinful person can use:

- ordinary speech,
- promises,
- vows,
- religious language,
- or oaths

for sinful purposes.

An oath cannot purify a corrupt heart.

24. Oath, Corruption, and Injustice

A solemn oath can be abused.

A person may use an oath to support:

- deception,
- false testimony,
- corruption,
- injustice,
- manipulation,
- oppression,
- revenge,
- or harm to innocent people.

Such an oath is not made holy merely because sacred language is attached to it.

Indeed, using God's name to support falsehood makes the abuse particularly serious.

25. The Evil Oath

This leads to a proposed theological category:

Evil Oath

An evil oath is not simply any oath that a person happens to dislike.

It refers to an oath corrupted by:

- falsehood,
- evil purpose,
- injustice,
- deception,
- corruption,
- or harm.

The Greek word **ἐπιορκέω** is particularly relevant when the oath involves false swearing.

The broader category of “evil oath,” however, is a theological synthesis rather than a formal lexical definition.

26. The Holy Oath

A second proposed category is:

Holy Oath

This refers to a sacred human commitment directed toward truth and holiness.

But even a holy human oath remains human.

It does not become God's oath.

Therefore:

Holy human commitment ≠ Divine Oath.

This distinction preserves the difference between Creator and creature.

27. Simple Truthful Speech

The third category is:

Simple Truthful Speech.

This category is closely connected with Matthew 5:37:

vàì vaí, oũ oũ

“Yes, yes; no, no.”

This is preferable to the expression “Simple Oath” because Jesus does not instruct His disciples to take a simpler oath.

He directs them toward straightforward speech.

Therefore:

The Christian alternative to oath-taking is truthful speech.

28. The Fourfold Theological Framework

The complete proposed framework is:

1. Divine Oath

God's perfect sworn faithfulness and promise.

2. Holy Oath

A human sacred commitment directed toward truth and holiness.

3. Simple Truthful Speech

Ordinary truthful human speech:

Yes = yes

No = no

4. Evil Oath

A human oath corrupted by falsehood, deception, injustice, corruption, or evil purpose.

This is a **proposed theological framework**, not a four-category classification explicitly stated by Scripture.

29. The Relationship Between Hebrew and Greek

The Hebrew and Greek word studies together show a consistent biblical concern:

sworn speech must be truthful.

Hebrew:

שבועה — oath

Greek:

ὄρκος — oath

Hebrew:

נִשְׁבַּע — swear

Greek:

ὀμνύω — swear

Jesus then intensifies the ethical concern:

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

“Do not swear at all.”

And provides:

ναὶ ναί, οὐ οὐ

“Yes, yes; no, no.”

30. Theological Development

The comparison allows a theological progression:

Hebrew Scripture

Oath must be truthful.

↓

Jesus

Do not swear at all.

↓

Jesus' positive command

Let your yes be yes and your no be no.



Christian ethical principle

Truthful speech should replace dependence on oath-taking.

This progression forms the foundation of the proposed theology.

31. A Necessary Scholarly Distinction

It is important not to make the Greek or Hebrew vocabulary prove more than it actually proves.

The Hebrew word **שבועה** means:

oath.

The Hebrew verb **נשבע** means:

to swear.

The Greek noun **ὄρκος** means:

oath.

The Greek verb **ὀμνύω** means:

to swear.

The form **ὀμόσαι** means:

to swear / to take an oath.

But lexical definitions alone do not establish every theological conclusion.

For example, the words themselves do not prove:

“Every oath is a legal crime.”

Nor do they prove:

“Every human oath is automatically false.”

Those propositions require additional biblical, ethical, and legal arguments.

32. What the Words Clearly Establish

The linguistic evidence does establish something important.

Jesus' statement in Matthew 5:34 is specifically about **swearing/oath-taking**.

The Greek says:

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

The word **ὀμόσαι** is not merely “speak.”

It is:

“to swear / take an oath.”

Jesus then contrasts this with:

λόγος

“word/speech”

and:

ναί / οὐ

“yes/no.”

Therefore, a central textual observation is:

Jesus moves the disciple from oath-dependent speech toward straightforward truthful speech.

33. The Meaning for Christian Life

This teaching has practical significance.

A Christian should aim to become a person whose ordinary word is trustworthy.

There should be no need to constantly say:

“I swear.”

The believer's character should support his speech.

The goal is:

truthful heart → truthful word → truthful action.

This is a deeper ethical principle than simply avoiding one particular expression.

34. Hebrew, Greek, and Christian Theology

The Hebrew Bible gives the background of:

שבועה — oath

and:

נשבע — swear.

The Greek New Testament uses:

ὄρκος — oath

and:

ὀμνύω — swear.

Matthew records Jesus saying:

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

“Do not swear at all.”

James repeats the prohibition:

μὴ ὀμνύετε

“Do not swear.”

And both passages emphasize simple yes/no speech.

Thus, the biblical language itself gives us a strong conceptual relationship:

Oath-taking → responsibility → truthfulness → simple speech.

35. Final Theological Proposition

The findings can be summarized in the following proposition:

The Hebrew Bible uses שְׁבוּעָה (*shevu‘ah*) for “oath” and נִשְׁבַּע (*nishba‘*) for “to swear.” The Greek New Testament uses ὄρκος (*horkos*) for “oath” and ὀμνύω (*omnyō*) for “to swear,” with ὁμόσαι (*omosaī*) appearing in Matthew 5:34. Jesus' expression μὴ ὁμόσαι ὅλως means “do not swear at all,” followed by the positive command that the believer's λόγος should be characterized by ναί and οὐ—yes and no. Therefore, Christian speech should be characterized by truthfulness rather than dependence upon oath-taking.

Conclusion

The Hebrew and Greek word study of “oath” and “to swear” reveals a rich biblical vocabulary.

In Hebrew:

שְׁבוּעָה — *shevu‘ah* — oath

and:

נִשְׁבַּע — *nishba‘* — to swear.

In Greek:

ὄρκος — *horkos* — oath

and:

ὀμνύω — *omnyō* — to swear.

In Matthew 5:34, Jesus uses:

ὀμόσαι — *omosai*

the infinitive form of **ὀμνύω**:

“to swear / to take an oath.”

Jesus places it within:

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

“Do not swear at all.”

Then He gives the positive alternative:

ναὶ ναί, οὐ οὐ

“Yes, yes; no, no.”

The significance is profound.

The biblical concern is not simply the vocabulary of an oath. It is the **truthfulness of the person who speaks**.

A human oath remains human.

It cannot become divine simply because God's name is invoked.

God's faithfulness is perfect; human faithfulness is limited.

Therefore, the Christian is called toward a higher simplicity:

Let the word itself be truthful.

Let yes be yes.

Let no be no.

The proposed theological framework can therefore be stated:

Divine Oath

God's perfect faithfulness.

Holy Oath

A sacred human commitment.

Simple Truthful Speech

The truthful “yes” and “no” of the believer.

Evil Oath

Sworn speech corrupted by falsehood, injustice, deception, corruption, or evil purpose.

The linguistic evidence does not by itself prove every element of this theological framework. But it provides an important foundation for studying the biblical distinction between **oath-taking and truthful speech**.

At the center of the New Testament teaching stands Jesus' command:

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

“Do not swear at all.”

And immediately beside it stands His positive standard:

ναὶ ναί, οὐ οὐ

“Yes, yes; no, no.”